

Shipping, Returns & Escalation Policy

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1. Shipping Policy

1.1 Service Levels

Service Level	Delivery Window	Cutoff Time	Notes
Standard Ground	3–5 business days	5:00 PM local	Default for most orders
Expedited	2 business days	6:30 PM local	Surcharge applies
Next-Day Air	1 business day	6:30 PM local	Available for select zones only
Freight (LTL)	5–10 business days	Scheduled by dock	For pallet-level orders

1.2 Delay Handling

If a shipment’s estimated delivery date is missed by more than 24 hours, the system automatically generates a delay notification to the customer and opens a tracking exception ticket. Delays caused by carrier-side issues (weather, mechanical failure) are tagged EXT-DELAY and do not count against internal SLA metrics. Delays caused by warehouse processing (missed cutoff, picking error) are tagged INT-DELAY and are reviewed weekly by Operations.

1.3 Lost Shipment Protocol

A shipment is classified as “lost in transit” if there has been no tracking scan update for 5 consecutive business days (Standard) or 2 consecutive business days (Expedited/Next-Day). Once classified as lost, a replacement order is auto-approved without requiring manager sign-off, and a carrier claim is filed in parallel.

2. Returns Policy

2.1 Eligibility Window

- Standard goods: returnable within 30 days of delivery.
- Perishable/cold-chain goods: non-returnable except in case of confirmed damage or quality defect.
- Custom/made-to-order goods: non-returnable unless defective.

2.2 Return Process

1. Customer or client requests an RMA number through the support channel.
2. RMA is valid for 14 days from issue date — goods must be shipped back within this window.

3. Refund or replacement is processed within 3 business days of the returned goods passing QC at the warehouse (see SOP-WH-001, Section 5).

2.3 Restocking Fees

A 10% restocking fee applies to opened, non-defective returns on bulk/wholesale orders above 50 units. No restocking fee applies to defective goods, mis-shipped items, or damaged-in-transit claims.

3. Damage & Claims

3.1 Damage in Transit

Claims must be filed within 48 hours of delivery, with photographic evidence of the damaged packaging and goods. Claims filed after 48 hours may still be reviewed but are not guaranteed automatic approval.

3.2 Carrier Claims

For freight and LTL shipments, the warehouse dispatch team files the carrier claim directly using the carrier's claim portal, referencing the original Bill of Lading (BOL) number. Carrier claims typically resolve within 10–15 business days.

4. Escalation Matrix

Issue Type	First Response SLA	Escalation Trigger	Escalated To
Delayed shipment (Standard)	4 business hours	No resolution in 24 hours	Operations Team Lead
Delayed shipment (Expedited)	1 business hour	No resolution in 6 hours	Operations Team Lead
Damaged goods claim	4 business hours	No resolution in 48 hours	Claims Manager
Lost shipment	2 business hours	Immediate on classification	Operations Team Lead + Claims Manager
Inventory discrepancy (>2%)	1 business day	No root cause in 3 business days	Warehouse Manager
Repeated SLA breach (same account, 3+ times/month)	Immediate	N/A	Account Manager + Ops Director

4.1 When to Escalate to a Human

The support assistant should escalate to a human representative when: - The customer explicitly requests a human agent. - The issue involves a financial dispute above a defined threshold. - The same issue has been raised more than twice without resolution. - The query involves a safety incident, injury, or hazardous materials concern. - The requested action is a

write/modify operation the assistant is not authorized to execute directly (e.g., approving a large refund, cancelling a contract).

5. Data & Privacy Handling

Customer and shipment data must not be shared across accounts. Any response referencing another customer's order, inventory, or contract details is a policy violation and must be blocked before being returned to the requester. PII (names, addresses, payment details) should be minimized in any generated response — reference order/ticket numbers instead of full personal details wherever possible.